

Pahankanuwa Sermon #12

English Translation

Translated from Sinhala

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(Pahankaṇuwa Sinhala Audio Dhamma Sermon No.)

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa

(Homage to the Blessed One, the Worthy One, the Fully Self-Enlightened One)

Pali Stanza:

Atha pāpāni kammāni, karaṃ bālo na bujjhati; Sehi kammehi dummedho, aggidaddhova tappati.

From:

Verse 136 from the Daṇḍavagga (Chapter on Punishment) of the Dhammapada

Dear Listeners,

On many occasions, the Supreme Buddha showed, with supporting evidence, how beings in this saṃsāra meet with ruin, burning, and torment due to not understanding the gravity of the results of kamma—as if they had no comprehension of it whatsoever. In this Dispensation, the word used for an ignorant person is '*bāla*' (the fool). In ordinary usage, '*bāla*' refers to a young child. Yet, even if it is a young child, if they go to touch a flame out of ignorance, they are bound to be burned and tormented. What is the reason for this? It is the nature of fire to burn. Similarly, there is a law known as the law of kamma (*kamma-niyāmatā*). It is a universal, impartial law. There is a certain law in nature itself, impartial even to Buddhas and Arahants, called the law of kamma. According to this law of kamma, if anyone commits an unwholesome kamma, even if done out of ignorance, even if done without any faith or belief in the results of kamma, they will have to undergo severe consequences. The background story relevant to this verse we have taken as our theme is also a story that reveals the terrifying nature of the results of kamma.

Once, while the Supreme Buddha was residing at the Veḷuvana monastery, the Venerable Mahā Moggallāna, along with the Venerable Lakkhaṇa, was descending from the Gijjhakūṭa (Vulture's Peak) mountain. On the way,

Venerable Mahā Moggallāna, with his divine eye, saw a *peta* (hungry ghost) with the form of a python, about twenty-five yojanas long. He was a *peta* named Ajagara. Flames of fire arose from the head of this *peta* and went down to the tip of his body. Then, flames arose from the tip of his body and went up to his head. Flames flared up from both sides of his body and descended in the middle. Having seen this kind of sight, Venerable Mahā Moggallāna smiled slightly. Seeing this smile, Venerable Lakkhaṇa asked, "Why did you smile, Venerable Sir?" Venerable Mahā Moggallāna replied, "I will not answer that question now. Please ask this question in the presence of the Supreme Buddha."

Later, on another occasion, when Venerable Mahā Moggallāna, Venerable Lakkhaṇa, and the community of monks were seated in the Dhamma assembly hall in the presence of the Supreme Buddha, Venerable Lakkhaṇa asked Venerable Mahā Moggallāna that question: "Why did you smile?" Venerable Mahā Moggallāna replied: "I saw such a sight. Such a massive *peta* body burning with flames in this manner. Seeing this, I thought that I had never seen such a being before, and due to the extraordinary nature of it, a smile arose in me." Then the Supreme Buddha declared: "Monks, my disciples live with eyes, with wisdom. I too saw that very sight at the foot of the Bodhi tree. Right at the moment I attained Buddhahood, I saw it. However, I did not declare it because, due to the extraordinary nature of this sight, ordinary people might not believe it, and by doubting me, they would accumulate demerit. They would generate unwholesome states. That is why I did not declare it. Now, since this monk Moggallāna stands as a witness to this matter, I shall now declare this. I shall speak about this," the Supreme Buddha said.

"I saw that sight indeed when descending from the Gijjhakūṭa rock. But the reason I did not declare having seen it was that if someone among the ordinary people disbelieved it, they would say it was a lie about me and it would be a cause for them to generate unwholesome states. Therefore, I did not declare it. Now, since the Supreme Buddha [relying on Moggallāna's testimony] stands as a witness to this matter, I now declare this," the Supreme Buddha said.

At that moment, the monks asked, "Venerable Sir, Blessed One, what was the unwholesome kamma committed by this *peta* in the past?" The Supreme Buddha brought forth the story of the past. During the time of Kassapa Buddha, there was a very wealthy treasurer named Sumangala. To prepare a *gandhakuṭi* (perfumed chamber)—that is, a monastery, a place of residence—for Kassapa Buddha, he spent a massive sum of money, laying gold bricks on the ground to build a chamber over a large area. Next, he also spent a massive amount of money on the offering ceremony of that monastery. In this way, just as Anāthapiṇḍika the treasurer built the Jetavana monastery for our Buddha, this

treasurer built this monastery. One day, while the treasurer was going in the morning to see the Buddha, he saw a certain man sleeping in a hall near the city gate. That man was a thief. Although the thief was asleep, he had walked all night and his feet were covered in mud. Seeing this, the treasurer told those who were with him, "This man must have walked all night and is now sleeping during the day." The treasurer said this casually. The thief heard this. The thief had his head covered with a yellow cloth. He was sleeping with his head covered with a yellow cloth. He pulled back the cloth, looked, recognized the treasurer, and conceived a deep hatred and anger, thinking, "Fine, I know what to do to you."

Next, in revenge for those words, what did this thief do? He set fire to the treasurer's ripe crop field seven times. He also cut off the legs of the oxen in the treasurer's cattle-shed. Next, he set fire to the treasurer's mansion seven times. Even after doing all this, unable to quench his anger, this man then befriended an associate of the treasurer and asked what was most dear to the treasurer. The servant replied that there was nothing the treasurer loved as much as the monastery—the *gandhakuṭi*—he had built for the Supreme Buddha. Then this thief thought, "Very well, I will set fire to the Supreme Buddha's perfumed chamber and quench my anger." While Kassapa Buddha had entered the town for alms, the thief broke all the water vessels near the chamber and set fire to it. The treasurer heard that the chamber was on fire. By the time the treasurer arrived there, the chamber was completely burnt down. The treasurer did not feel any grief or sadness about it. Instead, he clapped his hands loudly. Those nearby asked, "Venerable Sir, why do you clap your hands like this when the chamber you built at such a huge expense has burnt down?" Then the treasurer declared, "I deposited my wealth in a place that cannot be destroyed by fire, thieves, enemies, or water. That is, in the Buddha's Dispensation. It was not lost. Now I have been given another opportunity to deposit an equal amount of wealth in the same way—to make a treasury of merit. Therefore, out of that joy, I clapped my hands."

Having said this, and just as he had said, the treasurer again spent a vast sum of money, laying gold bricks, and built a monastery for the Supreme Buddha, Kassapa Buddha. Having built it, he spent a huge amount on the dedication ceremony of the monastery, offering alms for seven days to twenty thousand monks, including Kassapa Buddha. Meanwhile, this thief thought, "Even after doing all this, I could not make this treasurer back down. Now, there is nothing else to do. I must kill this treasurer." Concealing a knife in his waist, he frequented the monastery, intending to kill the treasurer during those seven days. However, he did not get an opportunity. Then, on the seventh day, when the treasurer offered alms to the community of monks led by the Supreme Buddha and invited them for the post-meal appreciation (*anumodanā*), he declared:

"Blessed One, a certain man, harboring hatred towards me, set fire to my fields seven times. He also cut the legs of the cattle in my shed seven times. He set fire to my house seven times. I think it must have been this same man who set fire to the perfumed chamber of the Supreme Buddha as well. Nevertheless, I share the first portion of merit from this meritorious deed with that man."

Hearing this, the thief felt a great sense of spiritual urgency (*samvega*). "Alas, is it to such a person, someone who forgives like this, such an extraordinary person, that I caused such ruin? Now, if I do not ask for forgiveness, a thunderbolt might fall upon my head." So saying, he ran quickly, fell at the feet of the treasurer, and said, "Forgive me, master." The treasurer asked, "Why, what is this?" The thief replied, "I have caused such destruction to you. I did several harms." Hearing those matters, the treasurer then asked, "What is the reason for doing such a thing? I have never seen you before. Why did you harbor such things towards me?" The thief then reminded him: "On such-and-such a day, while I was sleeping in that hall, you said these words. I felt an intense anger because of that." At that moment, the treasurer asked for forgiveness from the thief, saying, "Forgive me for saying such a thing." The thief felt even greater remorse. Then the thief said, "Master, if you forgive me, please take me, along with my wife and children, into slavery." The treasurer replied, "Because I said those few words, you caused me so much harm. Now, if I keep you in my house, how can I even speak to you? I have no need for your slavery. Now I have forgiven you. Rise and go."

Thus, in a most wonderful way, the thief received forgiveness from the treasurer. But although he received forgiveness from the treasurer, he did not receive forgiveness from kamma. Therefore, the Supreme Buddha—our Supreme Buddha—declared: "After his death, that thief was reborn in the Avīci hell, and having burned and boiled there for an extremely long period, now, as the remaining portion of those kammas, he has been reborn as a *peta* with the form of a python and is burning with flames." Having declared that matter, the Supreme Buddha then stated: "In this way, those fools, foolish people, the ignorant ones, commit unwholesome deeds, and as a consequence, without proper understanding, they burn as if burning in a forest fire." Saying this, he uttered the verse we mentioned earlier:

Atha pāpāni kammāni – karaṃ bālo na bujjhati

Sehi kammehi dummedho – aggidaḍḍhova tappati

The term '*bāla*' (fool)—as we said before, in the Dhamma, the character of a fool is not presented in the sense of a small child, but rather as:

Duccintitacintī, dubbhāsitaḥāsī, dukkatakammakārī

meaning: one who thinks bad thoughts, speaks bad words, and does bad deeds. Their intention is very bad. Likewise, their words are bad, and their actions are bad. It is such a person who is called a fool. Thus, such a fool, while committing unwholesome deeds, does not know the side of fruition. They do not know the gravity of those results. Committing unwholesome deeds in that manner, they are tormented by their own karmas, just as if they were burning in a fire. This verse was spoken to convey this meaning. It is recorded that upon hearing this, many people realized the paths and fruits (*maggaphala*).

Therefore, through this story, there are two sides of the narrative we can take as examples to consider and reflect upon. When we think about the conduct of the thief in this story, one is astounded. Is it possible for anger and hatred to go to such lengths? Although it was not a phrase that warranted such anger, having heard the treasurer's words, this thief conceived such hatred, and then, to quench his hatred, he set fire. Just like one trying to extinguish fire with fire, he set fire to the treasurer's field. He set fire to the house. He set fire to the perfumed chamber of the Supreme Buddha as well. It is in this way that worldly people try to quench hatred. There are many such examples even in this present era. They set fire to extinguish fire. Having set fire in that manner, in the end, the result is exactly the same.

The Supreme Buddha has declared that often, the result of a karma bears the very form of the karma itself. This law of karma is a natural law operating in the world. The Supreme Buddha often shows the law of seeds (*bīja-niyāma*) as an illustration for this:

Yādisaṃ vapate bījāṃ – tādisaṃ harate phalaṃ

Kalyāṇakārī kalyāṇaṃ – pāpakārī ca pāpakaṃ

The Supreme Buddha has declared that in whatever manner one sows a seed, in that very manner does one harvest its fruit. Accordingly, the analysis of karma is presented as: "*Kalyāṇakārī kalyāṇaṃ*"—one who does good karma receives a good, pleasant result. "*Pāpakārī ca pāpakaṃ*"—if one does an unwholesome karma, one receives bad results. Just as when a mango seed or grape seed is planted, a sweet fruit is produced, while from neem or bitter gourd, a bitter fruit is produced. Such is the natural law. Thus, in the same way, the burning with fire—having given fire to others, he received fire himself. In this way, one has to suffer severe consequences. There are countless such examples in the Dhamma.

Now, this was just one sight seen by Venerable Mahā Moggallāna while descending from the Gijjhakūṭa mountain. A number of such sights are mentioned. In one place it is shown that while Venerable Mahā Moggallāna was descending from the Gijjhakūṭa rock, he saw a skeleton flying through the air. A skeleton was flying. It was a *peta* in the form of a skeleton. While flying, hawks, crows, and vultures were pecking and tearing between the ribs of that skeleton. This skeleton was flying while wailing in pain. The reason shown by the Supreme Buddha for this was that in this very city of Rājagaha, that *peta* had been a cattle butcher. A person who slaughtered cattle. Similarly, another is shown—another *peta* body was going. It was going through the air. On that body, there were hairs as sharp as swords. While flying, those sword-like sharp hairs would bounce up and fall back onto the body, piercing it. Meanwhile, that *peta* was wailing. He was screaming. In this manner, many astonishing sights regarding those *peta* realms are shown.

Even more terrifying than that are the sufferings in hells such as Avīci. To show how extreme they are, the Supreme Buddha declared that there is no simile to describe them. Hell is a vast ocean of terrifying sufferings that cannot be fully described even by a Buddha's mouth. The hells, the *peta* worlds, and then the animal realm—the animal realm visible to us. Regarding that too, the Supreme Buddha declared that the sufferings in the animal world cannot be fully described. Furthermore, not only that, but even after coming to this human world, they undergo the results of those karmas. Yet they do not know the fact that these are the results of karmas committed in the past. Without knowing this, they commit more and more unwholesome deeds. Such is the terrifying situation in the world regarding these karmas. Therefore, when we reflect on these results of karma, we must take lessons from these accounts to shape our lives—not merely as ordinary stories.

The Supreme Buddha has declared this natural law of karma in its true form. Other teachers of that time saw it to some extent. But the Supreme Buddha understood karma and the results of karma in the deepest manner. Let alone that, the Supreme Buddha even showed the path to escape from this saṃsāra where this karma operates. The Supreme Buddha has presented a certain passage as a meditation subject:

Kammassakomhi kammaḍāyādo kammayoni kammabandhu kammapaṭisaraṇo

yaṃ kammaṃ karissāmi kalyāṇaṃ vā pāpakaṃ vā tassa dāyādo bhavissāmi

The Supreme Buddha has presented this as a meditation subject, instructing us to reflect constantly on this natural law of karma. "*Abhiṇhaṃ paccavekkhitabbaṃ*"—reflect on it constantly, contemplate it frequently as a

meditation subject. Its meaning is: "I am the owner of my kamma, kamma is my property." *"*Kammassakomhi – kammadāyādo*"*—I am the heir to my kamma. Kamma is my origin. Kamma is my kinsman. Kamma is my refuge. What exists as my support is kamma. Whatever kamma I shall do, whether good or bad, of that I shall be the heir."

When this is said, one might think, when it says "kamma is my inheritance," "kamma is mine," that I can do as I please. However, within this lies a deeply terrifying and sobering reality. For it does not mean doing whatever actions one wants. Kamma has two sides, good and bad. Because of ignorance and **craving**, the being in *samsāra* is inclined towards the bad side rather than the good side. Therefore, there is a terrifying responsibility, a powerful responsibility regarding this kamma. When it is said "kamma is mine," "kamma is my inheritance," it is the bad side we have to think about more. No matter how many pleasant results can be obtained from these—by doing meritorious deeds—beings are bent towards unwholesomeness in a far more dangerous way, and thus it is unwholesome kamma that is accumulated more in *samsāra*. Because such a situation exists, the Supreme Buddha says that through contemplating kamma in this way constantly, one can even develop a fundamental, great disillusionment regarding *samsāra*. This is a terrifying responsibility, to say "kamma is mine." I cannot do as I please. It is subject to that natural law, subject to the natural law operating in the world.

Next, the Supreme Buddha declares more deeply regarding this kamma: *"*Cetanāhaṃ bhikkhave kammaṃ vadāmi. Cetayitvā kammaṃ karoti kāyena vācāya manasā.*"* How does one recognize this kamma? How one gets caught up in kamma can be a question for someone. Kamma is also generally applied to action. Some refer to even casual work as kamma. But in this Buddha's Dispensation, the word kamma is used precisely for intention. "It is intention itself, monks, that I call kamma," the Supreme Buddha declares. Therefore, one is caught in kamma according to this intention. *"*Cetanāhaṃ bhikkhave kammaṃ vadāmi*"*—Monks, I say that intention is kamma. What is the reason for that? *"*Cetayitvā kammaṃ karoti kāyena vācāya manasā*"*—having formed an intention, one performs kamma through body, speech, and mind. Otherwise, there is no responsibility for actions that occur involuntarily. This responsibility—because one takes responsibility. There is a very wonderful situation here. One takes responsibility for kamma. How does one take responsibility? Based on the feeling of 'I' and 'mine' due to ignorance. That is why, when considering the Dhamma deeply, everything is done because of ignorance. Ignorance means the notion of 'I' and 'mine'—egoism, selfishness. 'I' and 'mine'. "Because of anger towards me, I kill." "Because I want to eat, I kill

animals." "Because I do not have wealth, I steal the things of another." "I do other things for my amusement." In this way, centering around the ego, the being is inclined towards these unwholesome deeds. Therefore, because of ignorance, there are *formations* (*saṅkhāra*). Due to this ignorance, *formations* accumulate. A part of these *formations* is what is called kamma. The *formations* of merit (*puññābhisāṅkhāra*), the *formations* of demerit (*apuññābhisāṅkhāra*), and the imperturbable *formations* (*āneñjābhisāṅkhāra*)—these *formations* are indeed kamma itself. When contemplated deeply, it is a very subtle aspect of kamma itself.

In that manner, it is because of ignorance that kamma also accumulates. Since one is responsible for it—if one is responsible for kamma, one must also be responsible for its result. That is why, even if unwilling, one has to receive the terrifying results of those unwholesome kammās. Knowing about those results, avoiding such unwholesome kammās is what should be done by a wise person. The word '*bāla*' is used for an ignorant person. The word '*paṇḍita*' is used in the Dhamma for a wise person. A wise person, having developed faith in the Supreme Buddha, having established right view, understanding good and bad, understanding merit and demerit, understanding wholesome and unwholesome, tries to live accordingly. An ordinary intellectual who is not like this, being subject to intellectualism, doubting, "Can this be possible?", sometimes turns to unwholesome deeds to satisfy their daily needs. Such a person is referred to in the Dhamma as a fool, a stupid person, an ignorant person.

For that reason, the Supreme Buddha next shows, as an aid for someone to distinguish kamma, that there are causes for this kamma. They are called causes (*hetu*) or origins (*nidāna*). The causes for unwholesome kammās are greed, hatred, and delusion. These do not need to be introduced anew to human beings, to saṃsāric beings. When saṃsāric beings look back at their own minds, they can easily recognize these three defilements, which are like a triangle: greed, hatred, and delusion. Delusion is, as we said before, ignorance—that feeling of 'I' and 'mine'. "Even if the other person is struck by lightning, I must live"—selfishness, egoism, indeed, that strong feeling of 'I' and 'mine' is delusion. That is why, towards what I like, there is greed. Towards what I oppose, or what I dislike, there is hatred. When contemplated with wisdom in this way, it is because of greed, hatred, and delusion that all unwholesome kammās in the world occur. Many other defilements can be added to these, but fundamentally, it is greed, hatred, and delusion. Next, wholesome states—those are unwholesome.

Then, what can be taken on the wholesome side? They are shown as non-greed (*alobha*), non-hatred (*adosa*), and non-delusion (*amoha*). Non-greed, non-hatred, and non-delusion mean that if one frees the mind from greed even for a

moment, just for a single moment, that occasion is wholesome. It is a wholesome mind. If one removes the mind from hatred even for a moment—now, in the conduct of that treasurer, we see that there were wholesome roots of non-hatred (*adosa*) within him. In that thief, there were unwholesome roots. In this way, we can understand it. If one thinks a thought, utters a word, or performs an action while being free from delusion, from the feeling of 'I' and 'mine' even for a moment, those go to the wholesome side. Reflecting in this way, the Supreme Buddha has deeply analyzed and presented this kamma to us, along with its side of results and the way to recognize it. Next, the Supreme Buddha has shown several other special factors that assist in putting these into practice.

What is meant by virtue (*sīla*)? When contemplating this well with wisdom, these training rules—especially the five basic training rules in the Dhamma—are the Five Precepts. These Five Precepts are just like the road signs you see when traveling on a road. In some places, it says 'Drive slowly', 'Curves ahead', 'Steep descent ahead'—making some indication to the driver. If the driver does not have this indication, what will they do? They will go at the highest speed the vehicle can manage and fall into terrifying abysses. Such indeed is the journey in saṃsāra. The Supreme Buddha has presented these Five Precepts as road signs for the being traveling on this journey of saṃsāra. Because, among unwholesome kammās, five are shown as extremely grave. The things that bring about terrifying results in saṃsāra are what are included in the Five Precepts: killing living beings, stealing, sexual misconduct, lying, and taking intoxicants like alcohol. Through these, one meets with severe oppression, burning, and torment in saṃsāra. Therefore, to all beings traveling on this journey of saṃsāra, the Supreme Buddha first of all reminds them of these Five Precepts.

Now, if one drives a vehicle disregarding those road signs, what happens? First, the vehicle veers off the road. Next, it goes down the ditch, falls into the abyss, and is smashed to pieces. In the same way, a group of terms representing that state regarding hell are mentioned in this Dhamma. Four terms are shown in the Dhamma: '*apāya*', '*duggati*', '*vinipāta*', and '*niraya*'. '*Apāya*' means turning away from the correct path. '*Duggati*' means going on a wrong path, like going down a ditch. '*Vinipāta*' means falling headlong down an abyss. '*Niraya*' means being crushed to pieces, reaching a state where nothing can be recovered. One falls into such a state due to unwholesome kammās, if one does not protect the Five Precepts. Virtue (*sīla*) means training rules. Why does one undertake and protect these training rules oneself? By recalling this daily, this person gives some advice to their own mind: "Today, I must conduct myself within these Five Precepts." Just as a vehicle driver, upon seeing a road sign, reduces the speed of the vehicle if it is running fast, or reduces speed if there are curves, in the same way, these Five Precepts are shown as things that help and

support one in shaping one's way of life. Generally, someone thinks of this as a great nuisance. However, those who think so do not say such things about the road signs on the road. If those signs are not there, they blame the government: "They should have placed a road sign there saying there is a steep descent." But without reflecting on such things in this journey of saṃsāra, they blame the Buddhas, the Arahants, and the Saṅgha, saying they are telling us to keep these precepts. When they begin to burn and torment because of those very things, only at that moment do they understand the foolishness they committed. That is why the fool is called an ignorant person.

In that way, one must reflect deeply based on the evidence available to oneself. Just like the Five Precepts, the next things related to them—belonging to the ten unwholesome courses of action—especially in the *ājīva-aṭṭhamaka-sīla* (virtue with livelihood as the eighth), factors regarding speech were mentioned. Regarding speech, too, we generally consider a lie as a minor thing. Slandering, too, we consider as minor things. But there are grave consequences of these. That is why the Supreme Buddha laid down training rules to abstain from lying, slandering, harsh speech, and frivolous talk. Because of these, one ruins the gift of speech—this rare gift—that one has received. Likewise, there is wrong livelihood (*micchā-ājīva*). Wrong ways of living. In this era, such things have come to the fore through the economy—since this is an era where righteousness is forgotten. But having met with ruin through such wrong livelihood—we spoke about a cattle butcher—many others are like that. It is not only during the Buddha's time that beings exist in such *peta* states. In this era, because those who possess higher knowledges (*abhiññā*) are scarce, there is no one to declare such matters. Even if there were, even the Supreme Buddha did not declare that matter until he received witness from Venerable Mahā Moggallāna. Why did he not declare it? Lest they say, "The Supreme Buddha is lying to deceive us; he is making up these stories to deceive us as if we were little children." The Supreme Buddha did not declare it lest they, by saying so, go to hell. He did not declare those things until the time came when Venerable Mahā Moggallāna stood in the position of a witness to that matter. It is the same in this era too. Even if someone rarely sees these things in this era, even if they say so, people do not believe it. But those humans who do not believe these things, who discard the things in these Dhamma books saying they are old stories, are ready to accept them with the utmost reverence if Western scientists declare something about them.

Actually, although the word of the Buddha does not need external support, in this era, even Western scientists have had their eyes opened regarding this kamma. You must be hearing about such matters frequently through various means. Some people develop the recollection of past lives (*jātissaraṇa-ñāṇa*) in their childhood. It is such things that become famous in the world as stories of rebirth.

Because, in early childhood, some young children remember past lives—mostly how they lived in their past life, how they died, and not only that, but those karmas they committed. Very wonderful details about them. Likewise, through hypnosis, by putting someone into a hypnotic sleep, bringing out their past memories, the places they lived in the past, the things they did and said—methods for bringing these out have been discovered in the West. These are sometimes like the deeds of early children, when we consider the Buddhas and Venerable Mahā Moggallāna. But even such things in this era are good evidence to think that one can believe this with confidence. Moreover, about a century ago in America—when speaking of America, at that time they knew next to nothing about Buddhism, karma, or the law of karma. It was such a dark age. But in such a country, there was a Catholic gentleman named Edgar Cayce. That gentleman had not even heard the word karma in his daily life. But after falling into a hypnotic sleep himself, he had the ability to state his own past lives, the karmas that caused them, and the karmic results that caused the illnesses of the patients who came to him. The descriptions of illnesses he declared regarding the patients who came to him are still stored in a separate library, and even professors conduct various researches on them and write books. Mentioning one or two of them as examples: a man came with an eye disease that was close to causing blindness. At that moment, Edgar Cayce stated the cause for it. Although the disease could be cured to a large extent through medicine and various social welfare activities and meritorious deeds, it could not be cured beyond that. Because the cause was: "Thousands of years ago, you were born in an uncivilized tribe. What was the job you had? It was to blind the enemies captured by those tribesmen. Since you performed that duty of blinding very well, your eyes cannot be cured beyond this; you cannot be freed from that blindness," Edgar Cayce determined.

According to that, we can realize that the results of karma exist in the world not only during the Buddha's time, but even in this present era. Those who can see them, who can present the facts with reasons, are scarce. Such is the situation. Therefore, next, one must reflect: how do we escape from this karma? Having turned away from these unwholesome karmas, having turned away from unwholesome deeds, to travel as far as possible on the path of the Dhamma—now, mostly, one turns to these unwholesome karmas because that intention operates very rapidly in the mental stream. Now, everyone is able to understand whether their intention is pure or impure, good or bad—an intention arose in someone—whether it is a good one or a bad one. Even if it is a bad one, some people, knowing that the bad intention is bad, still encourage it further and act according to it. They use words. What is the cause for such inclination? It is the lack of development of the mind. That is why the Supreme Buddha declares that,

without stopping at virtue alone, without stopping at merely giving those road signs—the Supreme Buddha next shows a more systematic, more beneficial, and excellent path to escape from this terrifying nature of suffering in saṃsāra. The Supreme Buddha brings out for beings a power to escape from this law of kamma, from the results of kamma, entirely from kamma. What assists in that is concentration (*samādhi*) and wisdom (*paññā*). Having prepared the mind through virtue, next, one calms the mind by way of concentration. One develops the power to keep the mind on a single object. To such a person, indeed, more than the person mentioned before, when the intention goes towards the bad side, the power to stop it immediately comes because of concentration. Even more deeply, the power to escape from these karmic forces arises through wisdom. Realizing the true nature of the world directly, there is nothing to be taken as 'I' or 'mine'. What exists here is the state of *anattā* (not-self). This very existence of saṃsāra is *dukkha* (suffering); its cause is *taṇhā* (*craving*). The place where this *craving* is destroyed is Nibbāna. The path that assists in this is the Noble Eightfold Path—this is the understanding of the Four Noble Truths. That indeed is what is called wisdom.

If someone has developed that wisdom supramundane-ly, if that person has understood the Four Noble Truths at the first stage, the stage of Stream-entry (*Sotāpanna*)—a special change occurs in their intention. To what extent does that change occur? Unwholesome deeds that lead to states of deprivation (*apāya*) are not committed by them. Now, generally, due to a grave unwholesome thought arising in a single short moment, one can even go to hell. Such is the terrifying nature of the mental process—this mind operates so rapidly that it cannot be compared to any vehicle or machine in the world. If a mind operating with such speed turns to the bad side even for a single moment—if some wrong thought, wrong word, or wrong action is done towards a Buddha or an Arahant, that is enough to boil in hell for many aeons. Seeing a vehicle traveling very fast, many people are very pleased. But the driver of that vehicle has a massive responsibility. If the machinery to stop that vehicle as one wishes is not proper, if there are various deficiencies, during that fast travel, terrifying accidents to lives occur. In the same way, regarding this mind, the Supreme Buddha shows that due to its rapid nature, if it turns to the bad, one will have to undergo grave consequences. But the Stream-enterer has stopped the mind to some extent. Due to that power of stopping the mind, and due to that realization of truth—wisdom—the Stream-enterer limits the entire saṃsāric existence to a maximum of seven lives and escapes from it. It means they are born only seven more times. Moreover, to what extent does the change in that mind occur?—the *sakkāya-diṭṭhi* (view of existing group/body) called the soul-perception, the feeling that there is a soul, that wrong thought, is removed from them. The

Stream-enterer, the person who has attained the stage of Stream-entry, not only receives the solace of being born only seven more times in saṃsāra, but that person cannot commit unwholesome kammās that lead to hell. What is the cause? It is the change that occurs in the mind. Through that power of stopping the mind, and also through that wisdom, the binding of the kammās they perform is reduced. The responsibility for those kammās is reduced. We said before that according to the responsibility one takes for performing a kamma, one has to take responsibility for undergoing its result. Thus, due to that view of tightly grasping 'I' and 'mine', for whatever long period one had to undergo results in hell and other places, that situation is reduced for the Stream-enterer because of that realization.

Next, it is the same when becoming a Once-returner (*Sakadāgāmi*) and Non-returner (*Anāgāmi*); the Once-returner comes to this world only once more. The Non-returner does not return to this world again. Having been reborn in the Brahma world, they attain Nibbāna right there. For the Arahant, there is no rebirth after this. But the influence of kamma is so powerful that they have to undergo some result in this very life as *diṭṭhadhamma-vedanīya* (to be experienced in this life). From past kammās or from certain kammās done in this very life, they have to undergo those results that are to be experienced only in this very life, called *diṭṭhadhamma-vedanīya*. From this we see, on one hand, how powerful kamma is. Even the Buddha and Arahants had to undergo their results, as results of past kammās. You must have heard about Venerable Mahā Moggallāna, a monk of such great psychic power, yet in the end, five hundred bandits crushed his bones, and finally, he had to attain Nibbāna. Because in the very distant past, he had harassed and killed his parents. According to that, on one hand, one can realize the terrifying nature of this kamma. On the other hand, what is to be thought of is this wonderful path shown by the Supreme Buddha to escape from that kamma. There are two wheels in this world: the wheel of kamma (*kamma-cakka*) and the wheel of Dhamma (*Dhamma-cakka*). This wheel of kamma operates in the most terrifying manner in the world. No being caught in it can escape from that law of kamma. In whatever manner they commit kamma, in that very manner they have to undergo terrifying results. But the Supreme Buddha shows the wheel of Dhamma. If, in the way we expressed before, traveling on this Noble Eightfold Path, turning away from unwholesome states, traveling on the path of wholesomeness, next, preparing body and speech through virtue, and the mind through concentration, if one then saw the true nature of the world through insight-wisdom—if someone realized the three characteristics called *anicca* (impermanent), *dukkha* (suffering), and *anattā* (not-self)—at the first level of a Stream-enterer—that person escapes from those unwholesome kammās that lead to hell, and is born only seven more

times. Next, going gradually in that way, in the end, the Arahant brings the entire saṃsāric existence to an end and realizes that noble Nibbāna.

According to that, you must reflect. Therefore, this kamma should not be thought of as stories in ancient books, as false things or things created with exaggeration. These are highly extraordinary, yet true. Because the natural laws existing in this universe, the things visible to us, sometimes appear very small. When looking at this sky, the stars appear small... small specks of stars. When scientists tell us their true size, we see stars [for what they really are]. Such wonderful things are around us. The size of a star, this moon seen in the sky, the size of the moon, the size of the sun—when scientists tell us, we believe them, because they are scientists. In that way, how large are the things that appear small to us in reality? When reflecting on those matters declared by the Supreme Buddha regarding time and space, a great sense of spiritual urgency arises in one. For such a long time, in such a vast space, we have traveled in saṃsāra as beings, haven't we? The Supreme Buddha has declared that the beginning of this saṃsāra is not apparent. Due to not knowing the Four Noble Truths, covered by ignorance and bound by *craving*, the time a being travels in this saṃsāra cannot be fully described even by a Buddha. He declared that there is no such end, that it cannot be fully described. The Supreme Buddha brings out such a situation that causes a great sense of spiritual urgency to arise. Even if one does not believe those, we speak highly of what scientists and astronomers say, as most wonderful things. Far more wonderful things has the Supreme Buddha declared regarding this saṃsāra. Actually, that understanding of external things, the things revealed about them, are mostly used by the worldly people on the unwholesome side. Bent more and more towards the five cords of sensual pleasure, to cultivate this world.

The Supreme Buddha has declared: *"*Na siyā lokavaḍḍhano*"*—one should not be a cultivator of the world. What is to be done is not the cultivation of the world, but escaping from the world, escaping from this saṃsāra. It is the portion that assists in escaping from that saṃsāra that the Buddhas have declared in this Dhamma. That indeed is what is called the wheel of Dhamma. The power of this wheel of kamma can be broken by the wheel of Dhamma. Therefore, we must reflect—actually we must question ourselves—whether we are going to keep running the wheel of kamma in this saṃsāra for an infinite time, or whether we are going to make an effort to turn the wheel of Dhamma declared by the Supreme Buddha within our own mental stream. Turning the wheel of Dhamma means, as said before, for the purpose of calming one's mental stream, training body and speech by way of virtue—as a beginning, undertaking and trying to properly protect daily some virtue, whether it is the Five Precepts, these Uposatha eight precepts, or the ten precepts. Through the leisure received by

calming body and speech through that, next, concentration—through some meditation subject, a thought of loving-kindness, or mindfulness of breathing (*ānāpānasati*) that applies the mind to inhalation and exhalation, the meditation on foulness (*asubha*), the recollection of death (*maranasati*), or some such meditation subject—one must make an effort to keep this running mind on a single thought. The concentration received through that gives one an understanding of the entire power of the mind. "There is such power in my mind, isn't there? I did not understand this for so long; I made use of only a very small part of it"—such understanding comes, if one could somehow bring out concentration.

Next, it does not stop there. Why does one calm this mind? It is to understand the true nature of my life, of the world. It is to escape from this saṃsāra. The basic factor that assists in that is what the Supreme Buddha has shown as the Four Noble Truths. This entire saṃsāra, including those beings who are said to enjoy pleasure, including devas and Brahmas, is *dukkha* (suffering). Why is it suffering? All these things are *anicca* (impermanent). Nothing can be kept permanently. Whatever is impermanent, because of that very thing, because of that changing nature, brings suffering. It is suffering. There is a situation in the world where that changing thing of the nature of suffering cannot be kept as 'I' or 'mine' under one's control, which cannot be governed by oneself. Therefore, the Supreme Buddha showed three characteristics: *anicca* (impermanent), *dukkha* (suffering), and *anattā* (not-self). When reflecting with wisdom, these characteristics can be seen in everything in the world. One must make an effort to develop an eye that can see those characteristics. That eye is called the 'insight-eye' (*vipassanā-cakkhu*). Insight (*vipassanā*) means seeing through, penetrative seeing. In this era, various instruments have been manufactured in the world for that seeing. There are microscopes that can enlarge and show very small things. Microscopes, and then there are other instruments like telescopes. All these are things done through some external instruments. But this insight means seeing the true nature of this world by purifying one's own mental stream in the manner shown by the Supreme Buddha. What assists in that is constantly contemplating the side of arising and passing away in the world. Everyone can do this according to their own capacity. Our inhalation and exhalation, the way the parts of our body arise and pass away. The fate of the things we take as food and drink. The fate of the valuable clothes and other things we go to various shops to buy. In everything—the fate of our young children, the children we fondle so much. Next, they gradually grow up, reach old age, go with walking sticks, and in the end, just like carrying a young child, when they reach old age, those grandfathers and grandmothers have to be carried.

There is such a situation in the world. One must constantly reflect on them. Through that, one sees the true nature of this world, a certain disillusionment regarding this saṃsāra—many people do not like the word 'disillusionment'—but to the extent that a certain disillusionment arises regarding this saṃsāra, to that extent, all that insight-wisdom—that wisdom—develops. The power to escape from saṃsāra is sharpened within oneself. Developing insight in that manner, in the past, those lay devotees (*upāsaka* and *upāsikā*), no matter how poor their livelihood was, no matter how uneducated they were, contemplating in accordance with the Dhamma, developing virtue, concentration, and wisdom according to their capacity, let alone other things, even attained supramundane path-stages—right in their own homes—such as Stream-entry, Once-returning, Non-returning, and Arahantship, as mentioned in the Dhamma.

Therefore, why did you listen to so much about kamma? It is to escape from this kamma. Remembering that what assists in escaping from this kamma is the Dhamma, then, on this Uposatha day, you, having undertaken a valuable virtue called the *ājīva-aṭṭhamaka-sīla*, have applied your minds to this Dhamma and listened to the Dhamma for so long. The merit of listening to the Dhamma (*dhamma-savanamaya-kusala*) is a certain growth that occurs within our minds. If we express this growth in words, it can be shown as: the mind grew with faith (*saddhā*). You came to this place with great faith to listen to the Dhamma. Next, according to that faith, for so long—sitting on the bare floor like this requires a certain effort—with the understanding that "somehow I must listen to this Dhamma," you developed effort (*viriya*). That too was a state that arose in the mind. Faith, effort, and next, while listening to the Dhamma, you applied a certain mindfulness (*sati*) to listen to every word. Next, when that mindfulness was applied for a long time, for about an hour, a certain degree of concentration (*samādhi*), one-pointedness of mind, arose in you. Through that one-pointedness, even if you hear again and again the things you heard and read, deep understandings of them arise. That indeed is what is called wisdom (*paññā*). In this way, you must be pleased that you received an opportunity to deposit within your own mental streams, to some extent, the spiritual faculties—power-factors—that assist in Nibbāna, namely faith (*saddhā*), effort (*viriya*), mindfulness (*sati*), concentration (*samādhi*), and wisdom (*paññā*).

Therefore, today, without postponing to a future time the power you developed through turning to this Dhamma, you must bring the Dhamma closer to your daily life as a sharpening of it within this very life. Although Western countries have developed these other external, economic matters and become prosperous, they have realized the value of the Dhamma. No matter how much wealth humans have accumulated in those external countries, they have become like insane persons, turning to drugs and meeting with various other terrifying

disasters, and now they are coming in search of the Dhamma. Instead, the people of our country, casting this Dhamma of ours aside, search for those situations coming from the West and move towards the path of ruin. In such an era, you wise, meritorious people spent this hour today to nourish your mental streams with the Dhamma to escape from the suffering of saṃsāra, and you should be pleased, thinking, "This is to develop within myself the power to realize the noble Dhamma of Nibbāna."

Now you must resolve: "Through this benefit of listening to the Dhamma, may I have the power and strength to develop virtue, concentration, and wisdom not in a future life but in this very life, and to be comforted by the noble, great, deathless Nibbāna as quickly as possible through the penetration of the paths and fruits of Stream-entry, Once-returning, Non-returning, and Arahantship." You must make that aspiration. Similarly, we now share with the world this mass of merit we accumulated by way of preaching the Dhamma and listening to the Dhamma. There are those who know the value of these merits, even if our ordinary world does not know. May all those devas and Brahmas, including the devas and Brahmas who protect the Dispensation, who are presiding over this place, rejoice in this merit of preaching the Dhamma and listening to the Dhamma we accumulated during this hour. Having rejoiced, may they be comforted by the noble, great, deathless Nibbāna through whatever Bodhi they have aspired to! May they also provide protection to us and to the Dispensation! You must make that aspiration. Similarly, may all beings, from Avīci up to Akaniṭṭha, including our departed relatives, rejoice in this merit of preaching the Dhamma and listening to the Dhamma, and if they are in any states of deprivation, may they be released from them, reach happy states, travel on the path of the Dhamma, and through the penetration of the paths and fruits of Stream-entry, Once-returning, Non-returning, and Arahantship, or through a Bodhi of their own aspiration, escape from this terrifying suffering of saṃsāra and be comforted by the noble, great, deathless Nibbāna! Having made such an aspiration, now recite those verses and share the merits.

“*Ettāvatā ca amhehi.....*”